

that they had to be bribed with frills to do an honest day's work. They preferred to sign on with wildcatting operators who offered no fancy extras, but who spoke their language and worked side by side with them on the drilling sites.

I'll never forget the time I began drilling on a property not far from the site on which a major oil company was drilling a well. Carrying its employee inducement program to ludicrous extremes, the firm had designed and built what its press agents glowingly described as the last word in drilling rigs. The entire rig was steam heated all the way up to the crown block. A neatly raked gravel drive led to the site. There were hot showers for the men and even a laundry that washed their work clothes while they waited!

Early one afternoon, not long after I'd spudded my well, a grizzled roughneck appeared on my site and announced that he wanted to see the boss. When I was pointed out to him, he came over and wasted no words asking me for a job.

"Are you working now?" I asked.

"Yeah," came the sour reply.

"Where?"

"Over there," the roughneck replied, nodding his head toward the deluxe drilling rig. There were no home

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comforts available for my crew, and I told the man so. And, I added, I couldn't understand why he would want to leave a job that offered such luxuries for one on my relatively primitive operation.

"I've been on that rig for four months," the roughneck growled unhappily.

"And we've only gotten down four thousand feet!" I laughed. Four thousand feet in four months was a ridiculously slow rate for drilling through the type of soil formations to be found in that particular field.